

Mobilizing Shared Commitment: Action

How do we inspire others to join us in taking action?

SHARED MEASURABLE ACTION

Goals for this session:

- Learn to commit people to joining you in action.
- Learn to design action that will motivate people to recommit to do more.

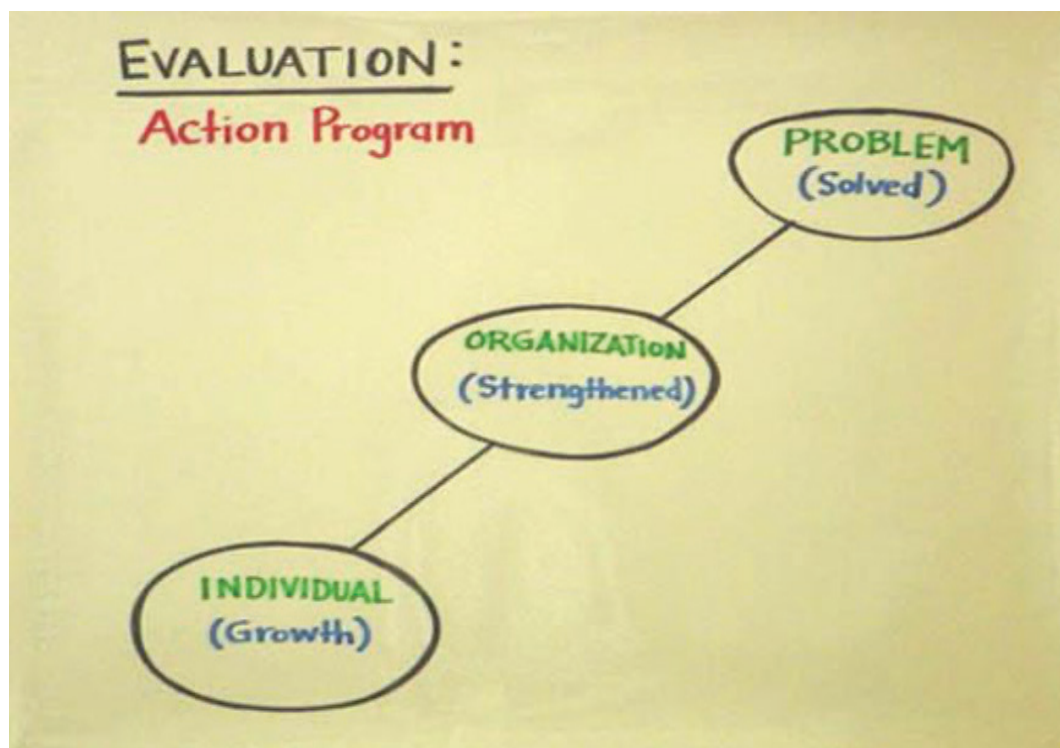
What is action?

Action consists of mobilizing and deploying constituency resources in ways that can create the power needed to win.

First, effective action produces results that contribute to accomplishing your goals.

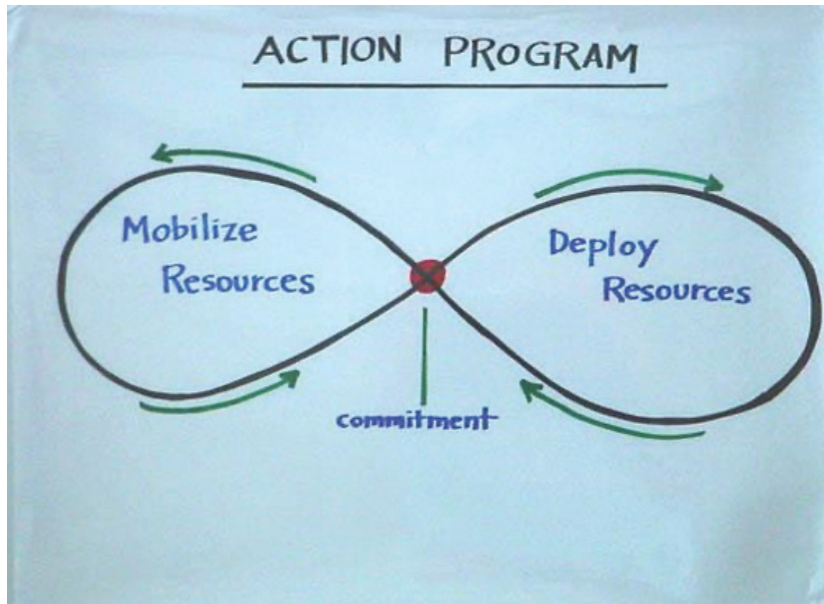
Second, effective action *strengthens your organization* and attracts and engages new people; it increases our community's capacity to effect change in the future.

Third, effective action contributes to the *growth of individuals* involved in the campaign; it develops leadership.



How can we engage in effective action?

Effective action requires commitment and motivation.



How do we get clear commitments?

First, we must mobilize others to make explicit **commitments** in order to achieve specific, measurable outcomes.

When we commit others to action, we are giving them an opportunity to make a meaningful contribution to a cause they care about. So why don't we always just ask? Sometimes, we worry about burdening others, or we worry that they will say no and we'll feel rejected, or maybe they'll say yes and then we'll have to commit ourselves!

When we ask others to join us, it is critical that we use clear, concise language. Sometimes we may try to minimize the commitment, making it seem smaller or less important than it really is. But respecting others means being very transparent about the work ahead, about the support they'll receive, and giving them a choice of whether or not to commit.

Mobilizing effective commitments requires four steps:

1. **Connect:** Make the “ask” as specific as you can to the person whom you are trying to mobilize. Identify yourself, why you’re doing what you’re doing, and let them know why you’re asking them to help. This can be done with few words.
2. **Context:** Explain why the action you are asking them to take is urgent. Be specific about the challenge and the hope.
3. **Commitment:** Explicitly ask the other person if you can count on them to engage in action with you. Be very specific about the date, time, and place.

- “Can we count on you to join us in _____?”
- “Will you join me in doing _____?”

LISTEN CAREFULLY. Is the answer:

“Yes! Definitely!” (Great! Confirm the details)

“Maybe . . .” (Ask what questions they have and how you can follow up.)

“No, I’m sorry.” (Ask why? Give them your contact info in case they change their mind.)

4. **Catapult:** If someone says “yes” then give them the respect of having real work and real responsibility at your action and a real plan to get there. Ask:

- Can you bring something to the event (i.e. food, posters, etc.)?
- Can you commit to bringing 2 friends with you?
- How do you plan on getting to the event?
(people with plans are much more likely to attend!)

How do we confirm and follow up on commitments?

In our Introduction to Organizing we gave the following definition of leadership: Taking responsibility for enabling others to achieve purpose in the face of uncertainty. Taking responsibility means that we can’t just get a commitment to action, pocket it like change, and walk away. We have the responsibility to follow up and do everything it takes to support others in joining us. Most important are “reminder calls” and the closer to the event, the more important and effective the reminder call will be.

- 1) **Recruit** others and get a specific commitment to action.
- 2) **Confirm** the commitment a few days out. Check in and see if the people who committed need a ride, can invite others, or can take responsibility for part of the action. **Confirm** the day before the action. Provide full details on the place, time and purpose of the action, including any updates on the agenda or attendees. **Confirm** one more time 30-60 minutes before the action—the period when we’re all most likely to find something more urgent to do. Convey how excited you are to have others join you in action.



- 3) **ACTION!** Lead a motivational action that respects others' time, but also provides full training, opportunities for relationship building, and purposeful, measurable action.
- 4) **Evaluate & celebrate** the action together. Tally up all measurable outcomes so that everyone can see that they're part of a bigger whole. Debrief in detail what worked and what should change next time. Then celebrate! Who wants to spend their free time without having fun?! Generate routines for how people in your organization celebrate together, perhaps with food, music or a round of stories from the day.
- 5) **Thank everyone** the next day for their participation in action. Tell them specifically what impact the action had in the campaign. Ask for their input on what worked and what should be changed next time.
- 6) **Move participants to the next level of leadership** where they can help you and your team plan more actions in their city or neighborhood.

How do we design motivational action?

For action to engage others in ways that expands—rather than depletes—our resources, we need to design action mindfully. If people feel that what they are doing is insignificant, or that they are being used, or that they must do boring and meaningless work, then they are unlikely to take initiative, solve problems or recommit.

Task Characteristics		Outcomes
Task Significance (TS)	<i>("the task really matters")</i>	Motivation Problem Solving Commitment
Task Identity (TI)	<i>("my contribution is clear")</i>	
Skill Variety (SV)	<i>("takes my head and hands")</i>	
Choice (C)	<i>("choosing how I do the work")</i>	
Feedback (FB)	<i>("seeing how I'm doing as I do it")</i>	

How does motivational task design work?

Outcomes: When a task is well designed, people who participate will feel more motivated, take initiative in solving problems, and make a deeper commitment to the work.

Design: Creating the experience to achieve these outcomes requires attention to these five elements of design:

- **Task Significance (TS)** – Experiencing the impact of the work on the world.
- **Task Identity (TI)** – Recognition of your “ownership” of a clear piece of the work.
- **Skill Variety (SV)** – Engagement of a variety of skills including heart, hands, and brain.
- **Choice (C)** – Having the space to make competent choices about how to do the work.
- **Feedback (FB)** – Results are visible to the person performing the task, even as they perform.

Designing Motivational Tasks

Using the checklist below, we can evaluate tasks to determine how motivational they are, redesign them to make them more motivational, and construct them so as to create a leadership ladder, opportunity for people to earn greater responsibilities.

Task Design Ladder

TI		
TS		
SV		
A		
F		

Getting into action now

The action we'll engage in at this training is to make a clear ask of your peers to support you in a specific, measurable action, and making phone calls to ask others to join you for your kick-off tactic!



Team Breakout Session: Action

GOALS:

Practice the core organizing skill of recruiting others to make a real commitment to translate their values into action.

AGENDA

TOTAL TIME: 50 minutes

1. **BREAKOUT:** Gather your team. Choose a timekeeper. Review the agenda. **2 min.**
2. **BREAKOUT:** As a team, decide on your goal for this exercise: how many total commitments will you need to get for your kickoff? How many “asks” will you have to make? Write it on the worksheet that follows. **5 min.**
3. **BREAKOUT:** As individuals, take time to note the key questions you will ask to get a conversation going, the key stories you will share to bring yourself to the table, and the specific “ask” you will make. This is not a “script” that you will read, but rather a guide for a meaningful conversation. Use the worksheet that follows. *Role-play an ask with your team.* **8 min**
4. **BIG GROUP: Start recruiting!** Listen for instructions.

For the first round, half the room will be the organizers, and the other half will be the constituents. The organizers have 10 minutes to have meaningful commitment conversations and get commitments for their kickoff event.

Each individual should use the worksheet that follows to track how many “asks” you’ve made, and how many commitments you’ve obtained. **15 min**
5. **BIG GROUP: Switch and start recruiting!** Now the other half of the room will have a chance to be organizers and recruit commitments for their kickoff event.

Each individual should use the worksheet that follows to track how many “asks” you’ve made, and how many commitments you’ve obtained. **15 min**
6. **BREAKOUT: Debrief with your team.** Organizers, return to your team to report back and tally up your whole team’s totals. **5 min**



Worksheet: Developing the Skill of Engaging Real Commitment

Step 1: Decide on your team's goals for this exercise and record it in the table below (3 min.)

TEAM NAME	TEAM GOAL: How many total commitments do we need?	How many people will we make "asks" to in order to reach our goal?

Step 2: Prepare for Your Meaningful Commitment Conversation (7 min.)

Using the story work you've done to help you write your recruitment call script. The keys here are that you **ask questions** to understand the motivations of the person you're engaging, that your story include something about **you**, and why you're motivated to act; you tell a little bit about **who your group is**, and **why they've come together now to work** on this; and **present the choice** that your listener has to make – join us at our upcoming action.

Don't don't worry about getting it exactly right; your conversations will each be different anyway – they should be conversational and respond to your listener, not overly scripted or formal. But here is a good list of sample talking points that you can use to orient yourself.

YOUR "SCRIPT":

Hi, my name is _____, and I'm at _____ today. I got your name from _____ who said you would be a great candidate to help us launch a local campaign next month to fight for _____ (goal) for _____ (constituency).

Some things to keep in mind as you prepare:

- 1) CONNECTION:** Let the person know who you are, why you care about this issue, and ask how they have been affected (drawing on your story of self and story of us).

Key questions to ask to get conversation going (remember to LISTEN):

- Have you heard about the movement we're building at _____? If not, let me tell you about it...
- Tell them about your experience here, the people, and the _____ campaign being launched
- How did you get started organizing? In what context? (on/off campus/in your community)
- How are you already involved with working on _____ issues?

Make note of the key parts from your story work that reveal your motivation to do this work:

- 2) **CONTEXT:** Explain what you and your team are planning. Provide details about who your group is, the exact challenges that move you to action right now, the real hope of what collective action can do, and a strategic choice.
- 3) **COMMITMENT:** Getting commitment: Will you join me in launching this campaign to do _____ on _____ date? What do you think?
 - WAIT for them to think and respond.
 - Confirm the DATE, TIME, LOCATION. "Can I count on you to be there?"
 - "Who else can you suggest I contact? Or would you like to help me recruit?"
- 4) **CATAPULT:** Next Steps: Thank them for their time, find a time that you can follow up in a few days, explain the recruitment process going forward.

If they said "yes" to joining you, give them the chance to lead. What roles are empty on your leadership team? What work needs to get done to prepare for your event? How could they help you?

Step 3: Start Recruiting

When it is your turn to be an organizer, write your name in row 1. As you recruit, keep a tally of how many "asks" you make and how many commitments you actually get.

Individual team members' names:	How many "asks" did you make?	How many commitments did you get?
YOUR NAME:		
Team member 2:		
Team member 3:		
Team member 4:		
Team member 5:		
Team member 6:		
WHOLE TEAM TOTALS		

Step 4: Team Report Back & Debrief (5 min)

When you gather to debrief, fill in the rest of the table, above, by having each member of your team report back the number of "asks" made and the number of commitments obtained. Tally up the totals for your whole team and see how it stacks up with your original goal.